

UTEP, Arizona Open WAC Play

By MARK LEIBSON

Times Sports Writer

The University of Texas at El Paso baseball team is flying higher than a kite these days and it's easy to see why as the Miners open Western Athletic Conference play Friday night in Tucson against the Arizona Wildcats.

Coach Andy Cohen's nine has already compiled a 21-9 record, far better than UTEP accumulated all of last season and more than Cohen had honestly expected.

"Sure I'm satisfied with our record so far. The boys are in a good frame of mind and feel they can beat anybody," said Cohen Thursday before UTEP ventured to Arizona to open WAC play with a three-game series against the Wildcats.

"I think our team can beat any college team in the country but that's a preliminary evaluation and I'd have to re-evaluate that statement after I see the other teams," said Cohen.

In years past, the Miners have always had a fairly good record going into conference games only to have the two Arizona schools take batting practice against UTEP pitchers.

Cohen believes it'll be different this year, although he's not predicting a WAC championship.

"Arizona is 27-18 right now but that doesn't mean they'll play dead for us," said Cohen of the defending NCAA champions. "But Arizona did lose quite a few outstanding players in pitcher-outfielder Steve Powers, centerfielder Dave Stegman and

catcher Ron Hassey, who's now catching in the Cleveland Indians organization.

"New Mexico is a lot better than most people think and Arizona State is always tough although ASU also lost quite a few people."

As for the Miners, Cohen thinks they've overcome several mental lapses they suffered in non-conference games "but that's what these preliminary games are for, to prepare the kids for WAC play."

Righthander Dave Jannusch, a senior co-captain for UTEP, has been handed the starting nod in Friday's 7 p.m. encounter at Wildcat Stadium, while Cohen has tabbed sophomore Jerry Walker and Freshman Wes Zott who has a perfect 5-0 record to date.

"There's the guy that's really done a job for us," pointed Cohen referring to senior Mike Rima. "He leads the team in saves and in wins with six. He's just done a tremendous job."

Cohen also praised centerfielder Bob Alsup, who has sparked several Miner rallies from his leadoff position, besides coming in to pitch in tight situations without having the opportunity to warm up.

Freshman shortstop Rusty Kennedy currently paces UTEP's hitting attack with a .400-plus average.

UTEP and Arizona will conclude the three-game series with a day-night doubleheader Saturday. The first game starts at 1 p.m.